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Ecclesiastes

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Ecclesiastes

A. Overview and Summary.

1. Reading the book of Ecclesiastes can be a confusing and despairing experience without a perspective of what it is intended to show us. In short, it provides us with a picture of what life is to someone outside of Christ. Such a person, as with the case of the “preacher” or “teacher”, as the Hebrew word “Qoheleth” is translated in 1:1, who is our guide throughout most of the book, finds no meaning to life although he investigates several ways to do so. He finds that all things are “vain”, translated from the Hebrew word “hebel”, meaning like smoke or vapor, or something that is fleeting or elusive. It is used five times in 1:2 and 29 times in other verses in Ecclesiastes.
2. Ecclesiastes is attributed to King Solomon, although there is no certainty for that. If so, it would have been penned sometime during the close of his reign about 935 BC. It is one of the “wisdom” books that include Job and Proverbs. Whereas Proverbs tells us that if we follow God’s principles, life will most likely be good for us, Ecclesiastes presents a darker possibility that this may not be so. The teacher makes note of this in 7:15: “In my vain life I have seen everything. There is a righteous man who perishes in his righteousness, and there is a wicked man who prolongs his life in his evildoing”. But in the end, the conclusion is reached as expressed by 12:13-14: “The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man. For God will bring every deed into judgment, with every secret thing, whether good or evil”.

B. Chapter 1 introduces us to the “teacher” or “preacher” by someone else (Vs. 1:1). We do not know who that person is, but he reappears at the close of chapter twelve. We are told that the teacher is the “son of David, king in Jerusalem” (Vs. 1:1) which seems to pinpoint King Solomon. The writer is probably using a literary method of someone who can draw a conclusion at the end by introducing someone else in verse two who relates their journey of seeking meaning to life throughout the rest of the book. The teacher tells us that all is vain “I have seen everything that is done under the sun, and behold, all is vanity and a striving after wind” (Vs. 1:14).

C. Chapter 2 tells us that the teacher tried to find meaning in self-indulgence through wine, building projects, agriculture, accumulation of slaves, animals, possessions, concubines and music. “Then I considered all that my hands had done and the toil I had expended in doing it, and behold, all was vanity and a striving after wind, and there was nothing to be gained under the sun” (Vs. 2:11). He continues to use the phrase “under the sun” to describe life in this world.

D. Chapter 3 presents the well-known verses about there is a time for everything (Vs. 3:1-8). He also tells us: “He has made everything beautiful in its time. He has put eternity into man’s heart, yet so that he cannot find out what God has done from the beginning to the end” (Vs.3:11). This is the first clue that the teacher will come to the conclusion that we will not find satisfaction in this life except in God in eternity.

E. Chapter 4 includes a lamentation about evil in the world: “Again I saw all the oppressions that are done under the sun. And behold, the tears of the oppressed, and they had no one to comfort them! On the side of their oppressors there was power, and there was no one to comfort them. And I thought the dead who are already dead more fortunate than the living who are still alive. But better than both is he who has not yet been and has not seen the evil deeds that are done under the sun” (Vs. 4:1-3).

F. Chapter 5 touches on the vanity of money: “He who loves money will not be satisfied with money, nor he who loves wealth with his income; this also is vanity” (Vs. 5:10).

G. Chapter 6 begins with a lament about life and not enjoying what has been obtained: “There is an evil that I have seen under the sun, and it lies heavy on mankind: a man to whom God gives wealth, possessions, and honor, so that he lacks nothing of all that he desires, yet God does not give him power to enjoy them, but a stranger enjoys them. This is vanity; it is a grievous evil” (Vs. 6:1-2).

H. Chapter 7 is a confirmation of Romans 3:23: “Surely there is not a righteous man on earth who does good and never sins” (Vs. 7:20).

I. Chapter 8 tells us why justice is not effective in stopping crime: “Because the sentence against an evil deed is not executed speedily, the heart of the children of man is fully set to do evil” (Vs. 8:11). But it does add: “Though a sinner does evil a hundred times and prolongs his life, yet I know that it will be well with those who

fear God, because they fear before him. But it will not be well with the wicked, neither will he prolong his days like a shadow, because he does not fear before God” (Vs. 8:12-13).

J. Chapter 9 presents the fact that death comes to all. We are advised as to what we should do now: “Enjoy life with the wife whom you love, all the days of your vain life that he has given you under the sun, because that is your portion in life and in your toil at which you toil under the sun. Whatever your hand finds to do, do it with your might, for there is no work or thought or knowledge or wisdom in Sheol, to which you are going” (Vs.9:9-10).

K. Chapter 10 is a collection of various proverb sayings.

L. Chapter 11 points towards the eventual judgement of God: “Rejoice, O young man, in your youth, and let your heart cheer you in the days of your youth. Walk in the ways of your heart and the sight of your eyes. But know that for all these things God will bring you into judgment” (Vs. 11:9).

M. Chapter 12 concludes the book of Ecclesiastes with the closing comments by the one who introduced us to the teacher in chapter one: “The Preacher sought to find words of delight, and uprightly he wrote words of truth” (Vs. 12:11). He closes by pointing us to eternity where God will judge every deed and every secret thing whether good or evil (Vs. 12:14).

N. Discussion Questions, Application and Passing it on.

1. Ecclesiastes provides the Christian with insights into a life lived apart from God. Seeking after “all things under the sun” will result in emptiness and despair. If there is no God, then there is no purpose or direction. A life without God is unfair, cruel, frustrating and utterly meaningless. How could you use Ecclesiastes to present the gospel of grace in Christ?
2. There are practical helps in Ecclesiastes to cause us to pause in all of our strife and our toil such as to “Enjoy life with the wife whom you love” and the fact that God has “placed eternity in our hearts”. How does this help us understand and deal with the setbacks that Christians will experience in this life? For the Christian, is this life truly vain? How would you respond to the teacher to counter his observations?

This Old Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)

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In Christ,

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